Walt Disney's iconic character Mickey Mouse first appeared in the 1928 cartoon "Steamboat Willie". In 2024, "Steamboat Willie" finally aged out of the current copyright limit set in the U.S. Constitution at 75 years (though Disney fought to extend that for an additional 20 years). My poster design, "Free Willie", refers to this concept. As intellectual property, Steamboat Willie was Disney's economic asset, allowing royalty payments and control over economic representations. The design shows Willie being plucked out of a primitive depiction of Plato's cave allegory, comically yoinked into the real world of forms. I compare this concept to intellectual property of famous Characters that develop outside of their immediate context and creation, and in the hands of a collective culture to develop and appropriate, transcending its existence as a property, and into a "free" character.

I used a still from the animated short, removed the background, and placed him in a starkly contrasted high-definition photo of a real cave, indicating he is being transported into a new contemporary setting. I used the ubiquitous Plato's cave allegory visualization in the foreground to reference his position as a controlled character, idea, and artwork within capitalist economic control. I blended the two backgrounds together with the seam blending tool and filled in the blank space around the lower image with the stamp tool. I then adjusted the contrast and made the whole image black and white to create some visual unity and reference to the original animated film.